

Agreement & Pronouns

Study Guide - Language & Editing

1. Learning goal

Make verbs agree with their true subjects and use pronouns that agree, refer clearly, and take the correct case.

2. What this skill means

Long sentences can hide the real subject behind prepositional phrases or extra details. Pronouns can also become unclear when more than one noun could be the antecedent. Strong editing means finding the sentence skeleton first, then checking number, reference, and case.

3. Do not confuse it with

Do not match the verb with the nearest noun unless that noun is actually the subject. In "The list of repairs is posted," repairs is plural but list is the subject. Also do not keep a pronoun if the reader must guess what it refers to.

4. How GED-style questions may ask it

Questions may ask which verb agrees with the subject, which pronoun correctly replaces a noun, or which revision removes an unclear pronoun reference.

5. Repeatable method

- Cross out interrupting phrases mentally and find the true subject.
- Decide whether that subject is singular or plural.
- Check every pronoun for a clear antecedent.
- Check pronoun number and case.
- Reread the sentence to make sure no pronoun could point to two different nouns.

6. Worked example

The list of delayed trucks is updated each afternoon. When supervisors discuss a delay, they record its expected arrival time.

Question: Why is is correct in the first sentence?

Reasoning: The subject is list, not trucks. The phrase of delayed trucks only describes the list.

Best answer: List is singular, so the singular verb is agrees with it.

7. Common traps

- Matching the verb to a noun inside an of-phrase.
- Using it, they, or this when two different nouns could fit.
- Using I or me based only on what sounds formal.

8. Diagnostic help

- If agreement questions feel random, reduce the sentence to subject + verb before choosing.
- If you miss pronoun reference, replace the pronoun with the noun you think it means and test whether the sentence stays logical.
- If case is difficult, remove the other person: "between I" sounds wrong; "between me" is standard.

Why this matters in ER: Clear agreement and pronoun reference make complex evidence comparisons easier to follow in an ER.

9. Quick check

Each of the volunteers has a badge, and all of them keep their badges visible.

Why are has and their both correct?

Check yourself: Each is singular, so it takes has. Them refers to all volunteers, so the plural possessive their agrees with them.